

The specificity hypothesis: a test in physical education and by gender-typed activities

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INTRODUCTION

The specificity hypothesis (Chanal & Guay, 2015) states that **autonomous motivation (AM)** is more specific than **controlled motivation (CM)**

GOALS

Extend the specificity hypothesis in physical education (PE)
Evaluate differences in specificity levels of the regulations according to students' gender

METHOD

Participants: 854 students from secondary school (12-15 years old)

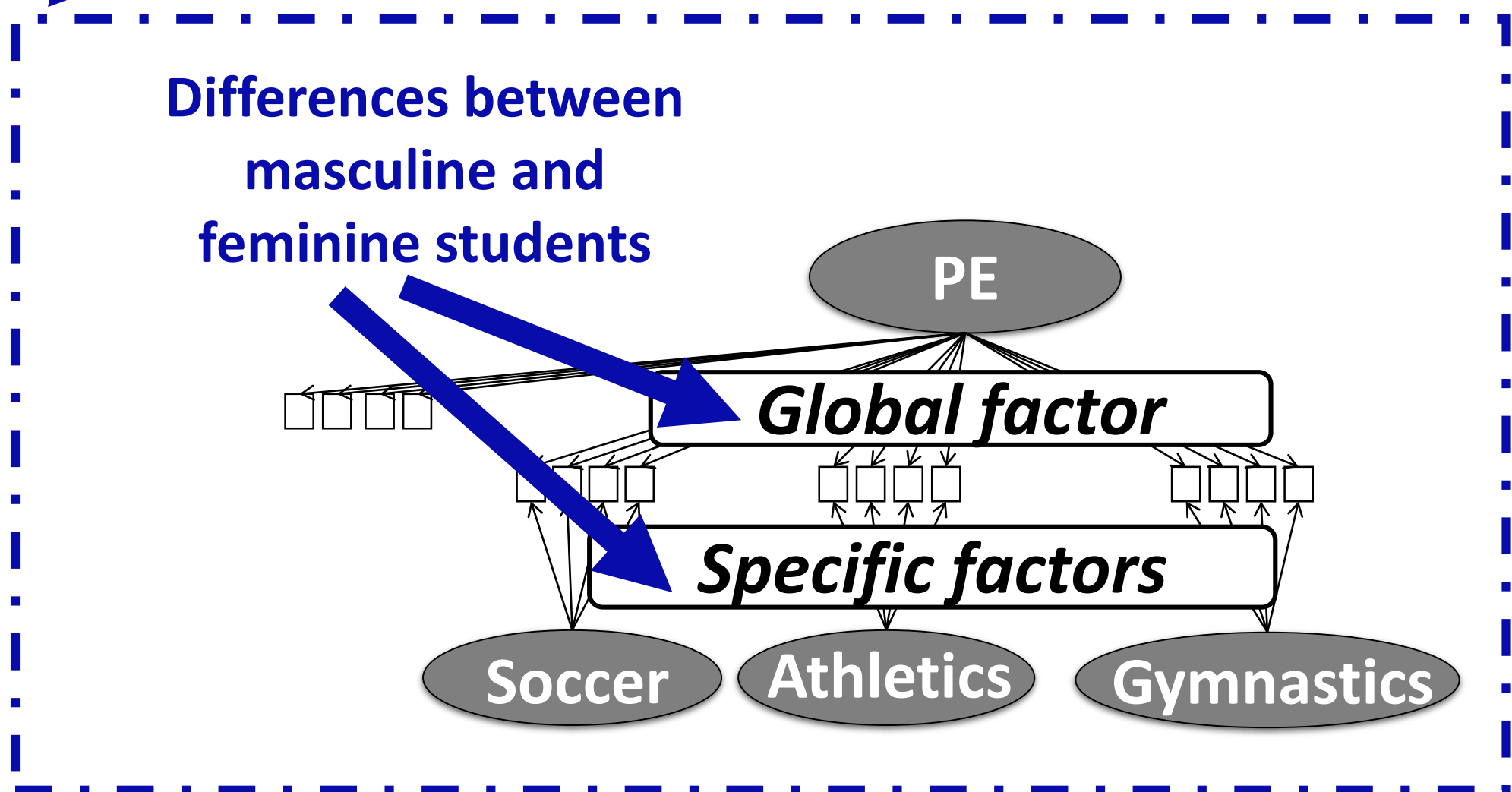
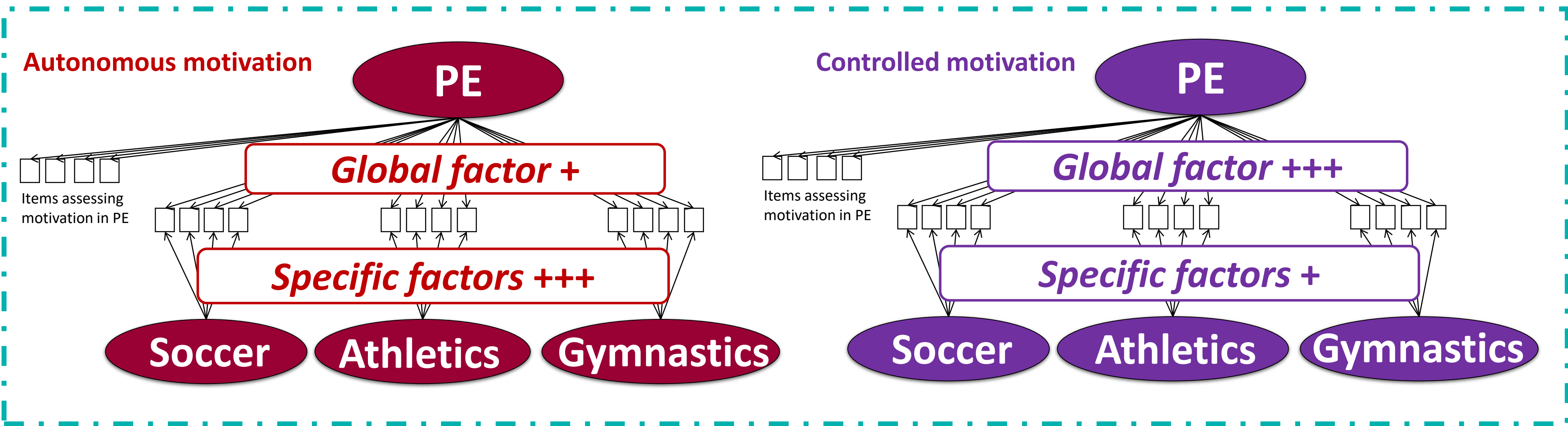
Procedure and measures: Online questionnaire evaluating:

- Self-determined motivation in PE and in 3 physical activities (PA) (i.e., soccer, athletics and gymnastics) (Sheldon et al., 2017)
- Gender (CSRI; Clement-Guillotin & Fontayne, 2011)

HYPOTHESES

Hyp. 1: Specificity hypothesis in PE
⇒ **PA-Specific AM** > **PA-Specific CM**
⇒ **PA-Global AM** < **PA-Global CM**

Hyp. 2: Moderation by gender



RESULTS

Table 1
Average variance due to global and specific constructs for each activity

	Soccer	Gymnastics	Athletics	Mean	Difference between Gender
Global					
Intrinsic	0.14	0.15	0.24	0.18	***
Identified	0.15	0.15	0.22	0.18	NS
Pos. Intro	0.30	0.32	0.31	0.31	**
Neg. Intro	0.11	0.12	0.10	0.11	***
External	0.08	0.12	0.15	0.12	*
Specific					
Intrinsic	0.72	0.68	0.58	0.66	*
Identified	0.62	0.59	0.50	0.57	NS
Pos. Intro	0.43	0.39	0.37	0.40	NS
Neg. Intro	0.46	0.37	0.38	0.40	**
External	0.34	0.24	0.23	0.27	***

Note. * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$. NS = non significant.

RESULT 1:
Specificity hypothesis:
HYPOTHESIS NOT CONFIRMED for Global → variance shared at the global level does not strictly increase from AM to CM
HYPOTHESIS CONFIRMED for Specific → variance shared at the specific level increases from CM to AM

RESULT 2:
Moderation by gender:
HYPOTHESIS CONFIRMED for Global
⇒ Items are differently related to global factor in masculine and feminine students
⇒ Students' perceptions of PA are differently related to PE depending on gender → "Centrality process"

RESULT 2:
Moderation by gender:
HYPOTHESIS CONFIRMED for Specific
⇒ Items are differently related to specific factors in masculine and feminine students
⇒ Students' perceptions of PA are different depending on gender → "Specialization process"

DISCUSSION

This study confirmed the specificity hypothesis in PE domain: variance shared at the specific level decreased along the continuum from AM to CM. However, variance shared at the global level was not strictly increasing along the continuum. Moreover, this study enabled us to demonstrate that individual characteristics (gender) could moderate specificity levels found.

These results thus provide first evidence that specificity levels could refer to psychological and developmental processes.

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